

An Enduring ENIGMA

The legend of Amrita Sher-Gil is further enlarged by her writings in this visual narrative of the artist's evolution brought out by her painter nephew

| By Yashodhara Dalmia |

The hypnotic charm of Amrita Sher-Gil has captivated audiences for several decades and been a source of inspiration to a whole slew of artists in India. This long awaited publication of her letters and other writings compiled with detailed annotations and a wealth of reproductions by her nephew, the artist Vivan Sundaram, provides new material and adds to the information already in existence.

Sher-Gil was not only a voracious reader but had considerable skill with words as these letters reveal. The first volume recounts the early years where she begins to take an interest in art, the Paris period where she trains and interacts with an international community and her return to India in 1934 to live and work. The sojourn to south India which inspired her masterpieces is detailed almost stroke by stroke by the artist and makes for fascinating reading. Sher-Gil's vivid accounts of her travels in the south and her struggle to paint, in her correspondence with the art historian Karl Khandalavala, also reveal her inherent propensity to be deeply immersed in her work and at the same time to distance herself from it.

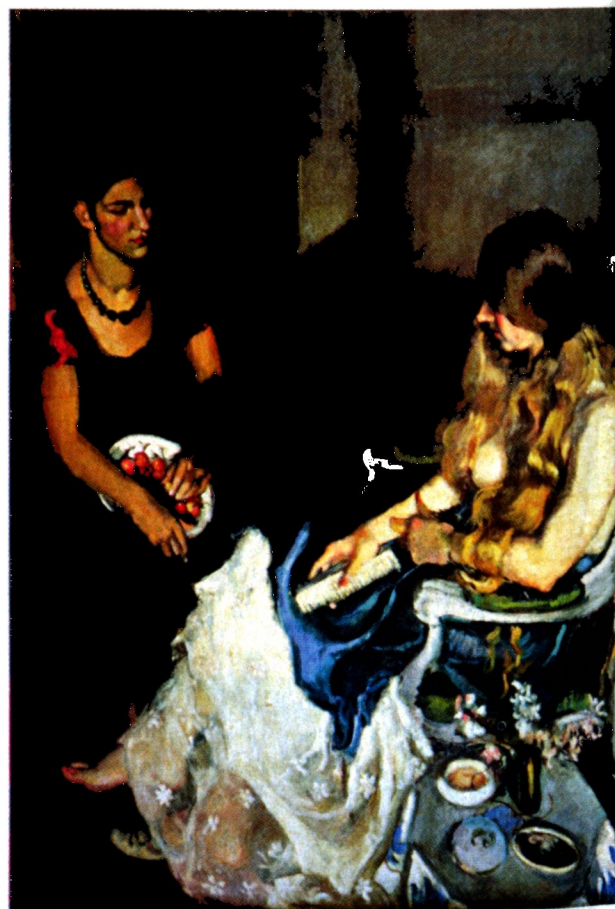
Her writings testify to her sharp and compassionate perception of the world around her. At a young age Sher-Gil writes in her diary of the child bride, who at the mere age of 13 will be married to a 50-year-old man with three wives. "Poor little bride, she did look forlorn as she sat in a lonely corner where around the room sat all the Indian ladies clad in gorgeous robes of gold and silver...". The extended Majithia and the Gottesmann families to which she belonged are etched out and create the matrix for her development.

The second volume has writings from her later life and sketch her attempts to root herself in India. We also get a tantalising glimpse of Sher-Gil's strong attraction for Nehru and vice versa in a few letters. In one dated November 6th, 1937, she writes, "I should like to have known you better. I am always attracted to people who are integral enough to be inconsistent without discordancy—and who don't trail viscous threads of

regret behind them." Since a whole bunch of letters of this period were burnt by her parents, we do not get any more information than already exists of this relationship.

In June 1938, Sher-Gil leaves for Hungary to marry her first cousin Victor Egan despite strong opposition from her parents. A childhood romance comes to a fruition and her instinctive feeling that the two would complement each other has some justification. The two return to India where she wants to live and work but unfortunately, the edgy opposition from the mother towards Egan drives the two away to the family estate in Saraya. It is here perhaps that Sher-Gil first encounters a world outside the charmed circles she is used to and she puts it to

SHER-GIL'S *YOUNG GIRLS*, 1932



AMRITA SHER-GIL: A SELF-PORTRAIT IN LETTERS AND WRITINGS VOLUME 1 & 2

Edited by VIVAN SUNDARAM

Foreword by SALMAN RUSHDIE

Tulika

Price: Rs 5,750

Pages: 417 & 811